

Conquered

‘Name? Age?’

‘Jack Hambower, thirteen.’

‘And who recommended me to you?’

‘My mother.’

‘Aha! And would your mother go by the name of Morgana Hambower?’

‘She would.’

‘Ay!’ I say, wiping a tear off my cheek. ‘She’s a close friend, and a great woman too. Anyways, what brings a young man like you to me?’ Classic tactic. Never fails. Nothing so thoroughly wheedles and coaxes a young teenager boy as being called ‘man’.

He says nervously, ‘Can I confide in you? Completely?’

‘Indeed sir, and I assure you nothing that passes between you and me today shall trickle out of this room. You made the wisest decision, approaching me, for I sit here day and night, waiting for another poor soul in distress, like you, that I may be of any assistance to. I am by your side, consider me your closest friend.’

He seems to be comforted a little, for the anxiety that was written in bold letters across his white, perspiring face slackens, his tensed muscles relax a bit. I usually have that effect on people within the first twenty seconds of acquaintance. He takes a deep breath and spills his heart out to me, a complete stranger. Ha! Teenagers are the easiest.

‘My mother won’t let me play on my PS4, and I had completed all my homework. I had done my studies for the day, and it had not even been four hours of gaming when my mother comes storming into my room, screeching about the state of humanity and today’s youngest generation, complaining about how disobedient today’s children are and so disrespectful towards their parents too, and how their generation as children used to be so respectful and...’

‘Ay! Say no more, son! Say no more!’ I cry, and when I do, you might notice how I change my address from ‘sir’ to ‘son’. This is a sensitive moment in the proceedings, and I know from years of experience that at this stage, a teenager is best lured if he finds in me, a motherly figure that he can love and admire much more than his actual cruel and tyrannic mother, a figure where he knows he can take refuge in.

‘I know exactly how that feels. I have been through exactly the same situation. You see, when I was a child, I used to absolutely love candies. And like you, even I used to maintain a tremendous amount of self-control, allowing myself to only five candies a day. But even at that, my father would shriek and shout and yell at me, and confiscate all my candies.’ Pulling out all the stops, now. I must present myself as a dependable and understanding, yet relatable elder. Make the correct show and the teenager is entangled forever.

‘But sometimes, I feel that perhaps my mother is right, perhaps four hours of screen-time *is* too much. Maybe it *is* wrong of me to ignore m-’

‘Stop right there, sir. You mustn’t let your confidence in yourself dwindle. You mustn’t let your enemies conquer you emotionally. That is how such people operate, sir, and you mustn’t give in to their traps. It is the worst kind of defeat. It is indeed a nasty, nasty business.’ I say shaking my head sorrowfully.

‘I tell you, sir, I have seen many such cases. Several of my clients disobeyed me, and fell prey to eternal emotional torture and suffering at the hands of those who never mean anything but harm.’ Careful choice of words. At this stage, it would be a pity if I lose the poor boy’s trust.

‘Hmm.’ Says the boy, thoughtfully.

‘Come on now! Four hours? I had rather be dead than be denied even four hours of leisure time. This is private invasion. I tell you, sir! That’s what it is! Aren’t you a man yourself? Can’t you take decisions for yourself now? Tell me honestly, sir. Don’t you feel violated when your mother just breaks into your room without any sort of permission? Do you have no degree of control over your life now?’

He looks down upon his knees, clearly conflicted from the inside. ‘But she loves me so, my mother does. How can she mean me anything but good? She must be saying this for my benefit, won’t she?’

I bite my lip. Then in a calm, composed manner, with just the right amount of tremor in my voice, I say, ‘Sir. You have fallen into the worst of the traps that one can cook up. Emotional entanglement. You just can’t see sense now. Your vision has been clouded. But no worries! That’s why we are here, aren’t we? I’ll show you the way. I’ll fight by you. And we’ll emerge victorious out of this together.’

My enticing voice seems to have an effect on him. It always does. ‘I believe in you.’

Perfect.

Then he says in a quivering voice. ‘Who is she to invade into my personal life? Who is she to command me to do things? I’m THIRTEEN!’

‘Very good! Very good! See? Making progress already. Go on!’

He continues with an increasing volume, ‘I can hear from my room, how she talks to her friends for five hours at a stretch. Who is she to tell me leave the phone? When she herself remains glued to the screen for eternity.’

‘Good point. Very good point. Do you have a brother? A sister?’

By this time, he is on his feet, yelling into the air above my hair. ‘Ah yes! I haven’t even started about that. It’s always Jack this! Jack that! Never, Lisa this! Lisa that! And look at her, she spends her entire day on her smartphone! Never takes her eyes off it! Why would she, too? Whatever *she* does is correct, isn’t it? For my mother, at least! She hasn’t any fear of being yelled at, at being criticized for every single move! Only I know how I spend my days, living

under the constant terror of being screamed at, of being tormented, pestered, taunted eternally. Do I even have a life?’

I keep nodding approvingly and encouragingly throughout his monologue. ‘Pity! Pity! Such a tragic life! Pity! Pity!’

‘I have always brought such laurels to you! It is not that I side-line my studies when I play video games! FOR GOD’S SAKE, I AM THE DAMN TOPPER OF MY SCHOOL! I AM JACK HAMBOWER, AND I WILL *NOT* TOLERATE BEING TREATED LIKE THAT! Just compare my grades with Lisa’s, will you! I won three football competitions and two debate competitions. I secured a second prize in a national quiz when I was a mere 7 years-old. JUST, WHERE DID I GO WRONG TO DESERVE SUCH A TREATMENT AT YOUR HANDS? Now tell me this!’

He rants on for another half an hour, confessing to me his deepest and darkest secrets, all the suppressed emotion. Perfect.

At the end of our session, he says to me in high spirits, ‘Thank you for showing me the light. I was an ignorant and an immature fool. I have grown up now.’

‘Bravo! Bravo!’ I exclaim proudly. ‘Now go, tiger and face all your enemies! Now go, tiger, and tell them plainly that you will not accept their atrocities anymore!’

When he is gone, I give a delightful sigh of relief. Huh! Another job well done! Another human set on the right track. Another lifelong acquaintance made! It is always a bit difficult to break the ice with newcomers. But it is just for the first time. After the first session, everyone is so cooperative and understanding! They follow my advice blindly. Especially, when a young human like Jack freshly moves into the period of teenage, he often finds himself misguided and astray. That is when I have to step in, mentoring and guiding the innocent minds.

People seem to have an unusual liking for me. Irrespective of who they are, what age group they are. I guess it’s just something in my nature, but I win people’s hearts everywhere. Wherever I go. And I happen to go to a lot of places actually. You could say that I am restless and unstoppable like the river. And then, of course, it also becomes a part of my profession to meet new people, make new acquaintances. I connect with some stranger on professional account, we eventually establish an intimate friendship, that person recommends me to other people in his/her surroundings, and I get to be able to help out another poor soul in distress, to make another potentially lifelong relationship. That is how a never-ending cycle develops, and that is how one develops fame and reputation in this highly competitive world. That is how I developed it, And I’ll admit, there’s not one place on the face of this earth where I’m not recognized. And when I’ll tell you my name, I bet my life on it, you’ll recognize me too, and personally at that.

It is not ten minutes after the boy has left, when an elderly-looking lady walks in, none to my surprise.

‘Ah! Morgana! I have been expecting you! What brings you here on this cheerful day?’

‘My son. He has been talking the most baseless and rubbish of all that he has ever said in his life. His behaviour is uncanny. I asked him to leave his PS4 for some time, the damned thing! (As you advised me to). And he started shrieking and yelling at me. Oh! And the terrible things he said too! I never knew he had such hatred suppressed down his conscience. He called Lisa *daft* and *cretinous*! And oh my! He called me, *me*, his *mother*, a *monster*!’

‘Tsk! Tsk! Today’s children! So disrespectful! No regard for their parents at all! Huh! I wonder what the world is coming to. Yes Morgana! I completely understand. In fact, I have a thirteen-year-old myself. He’s the most hateful creature that was ever born. I try to stop him, but he won’t listen, would he? He gobbles down candy after candy. I try to negotiate with him friendly, try to reason with him, say that someday all his teeth are going to fall out of his mouth, if he keeps on going like this. He never understands.’, I say.

‘What should I do with him? What should I do with him? I don’t trust anyone as much as I trust you, and I seek your advice.’

‘Well, haven’t I trained you well enough Morgana? Are you not such an accomplished parent already?’

She doesn’t take as long as her son. In fact, she doesn’t take any time at all, and bursts. ‘You’re right. I was a fool not to see the light back then. Who is he to shout at me like that? Where would he be, if it were not for *my* support backing him all the time? Would he have achieved those grades if *I* didn’t teach him tirelessly all those nights before the exams? Would he have won those football matches at all, if *I* hadn’t forced him to join the school’s football team? AND HE DARE THROW ALL OF THAT IN *MY* FACE AS IF IT WAS ALL HIS DOING! HE DARE DISRESPECT *ME*!’

She pauses, breathing heavily, and then bursts out again. ‘Does he think that I have no life of my own? Does he think that I have no work other than to tend to his tantrums! I have friends of my own, whom I have known longer than he has been on this earth! Where does he think he gets his debating skills from? From me, of course! He could have inherited nothing more from his father than his unnaturally horrid looks! *I*, who won six debating competitions in my youth. *I*, who was the national topper in my engineering exams! *I*, who secured first rank in four music competitions! *I*, MORGANA HAMBOWER! I WILL *NOT* TOLERATE BEING TREATED LIKE THAT AT THE HANDS OF *MY* SON.’

She finished, gasping for air.

‘Good job, Morgana!’, I say, clapping triumphantly. ‘Now go, my queen, and teach that insolent little creature a lesson or two!’

She storms out of the room, and I sit back on my chair, content with a good day’s work. There’s nothing in this world that pleases me more than to watch a family break-down. Indeed, to be honest, that is my profession.

I said before that I win people’s hearts. I’ll elaborate. I win people’s hearts, I take over their emotions, I conquer their minds. I cloud their brains, working my magic upon the weakest of their points; their insecurities and their feelings of guilt. I thoroughly handicap their ability to

think clearly, logically and sensibly. And then, I offer them refuge. A place where they are never wrong, where no one can blame them of anything. And they walk into my outstretched arms. As readily as a baby does into his mother's.

Indeed, I am inevitable. For I am bringer of destruction. I am harbinger of strife. I am augury of hostility and war. I am born of hatred and profess hatred. I am vanity. I am conceit. I am human Anger.

- Manan Garg
X-B